

Thermodynamics

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Contents

1	Energy and Enthalpy	2
1.1	Potential and Kinetic Energy	2
1.2	Heat	3
1.3	Enthalpy	5
2	Entropy	9
2.1	Defining Entropy	9
2.2	Changes in Entropy	12
3	Gibbs Free Energy	13
3.1	Gibbs Free Energy	13
3.2	Free Energy & Equilibrium	16
4	Examples and Applications	17
4.1	Work	17
4.2	Electrochemical Cells	19

1 Energy and Enthalpy

1.1 Potential and Kinetic Energy

Core Concept 1.1: Thermodynamics

Thermodynamics examines the **energy changes** that accompany chemical reactions and phase transitions, enabling us to predict both whether a reaction will proceed **spontaneously** and **how much energy it will release or absorb**.

In chemistry, energy is broadly classified into two fundamental categories.

Core Concept 1.2: Kinetic Energy

Kinetic Energy (KE) refers to the energy associated with the motion of a molecule and is broadly categorized into **vibrational**, **rotational**, and **translational** motion.

Core Concept 1.3: Potential Energy

Potential Energy (PE) refers to the energy stored within intra- and intermolecular interactions. These interactions are governed by electrostatic attractions between opposing charges (e^- and $protons$) within a system, a principle formally described by **Coulomb's Law**.

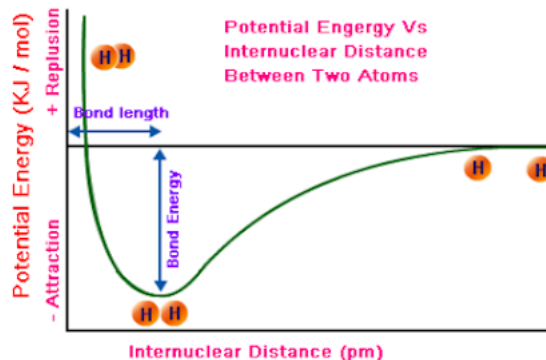


Figure 1: Potential Energy

As shown in Figure 1, intramolecular bonds arrange themselves at internuclear distances that **minimize PE**. When the internuclear distance is **infinitely large**, PE approaches zero, as the force between atoms is negligible.

As atoms approach one another, they reach an equilibrium point at which repulsive (*like-charge*) and attractive (*opposing-charge*) forces balance. The PE at this equilibrium is defined as the **bond energy**, and its formation is accompanied by a release of energy—analogueous to two magnets snapping together. Conversely, compressing atoms beyond this equilibrium causes PE to rise, as repulsive forces begin to dominate—analogueous to two rubber balls being forced together. *Bond energy is more rigorously characterized by the thermodynamic quantity **enthalpy**, discussed further in Core Concept 1.8.*

These observations give rise to two fundamental principles.

- **Breaking** a bond requires an **input of energy**; the change in PE from the bonded to unbonded state is therefore negative.
- **Forming** a bond releases an **output of energy**; the change in PE from the unbonded to bonded state is therefore positive.

Core Concept 1.4: The First Law of Thermodynamics

Within a **closed system**, the total energy is defined as the sum of its kinetic and potential energies:

$$E_{total} = KE + PE$$

This relationship reflects the **First Law of Thermodynamics**, which states that energy is neither created nor destroyed, but interconverted between KE and PE. When **PE decreases**—for instance, as two atoms form a bond and settle into a lower-energy configuration—the system gains a corresponding amount of KE. This conversion underlies **exothermic** reactions (Core Concept 1.5), in which the stabilization of chemical bonds manifests as increased molecular motion and the release of heat.

Conversely, when **KE decreases**—as when a molecule decelerates against an attractive intermolecular force—that energy is not lost, but transferred into PE as the molecule ascends a potential energy well shown in Figure 1

1.2 Heat

Core Concept 1.5: Endothermicity & Exothermicity

Chemical reactions can be classified based on the direction of heat flow between the system and its surroundings. In an **exothermic reaction**, energy is **released** into the surroundings—the products are at a lower energy state than the reactants, and the excess energy is dissipated as thermal energy. *Take the combustion of gasoline as an example.*

Conversely, in an **endothermic reaction**, energy is **absorbed** from the surroundings in order to drive the reaction forward—the products are at a higher energy state than the reactants, necessitating a net input of thermal energy. *A familiar example is the dissolution of ammonium nitrate in water, the principle underlying instant cold packs: as the reaction proceeds, it draws heat from the surrounding environment, producing a pronounced drop in temperature.*

Core Concept 1.6: Heat Transfer & Calorimetry

Heat transfer occurs when two systems at differing temperatures come into contact, whereupon thermal energy flows from the system of higher temperature to that of lower temperature.

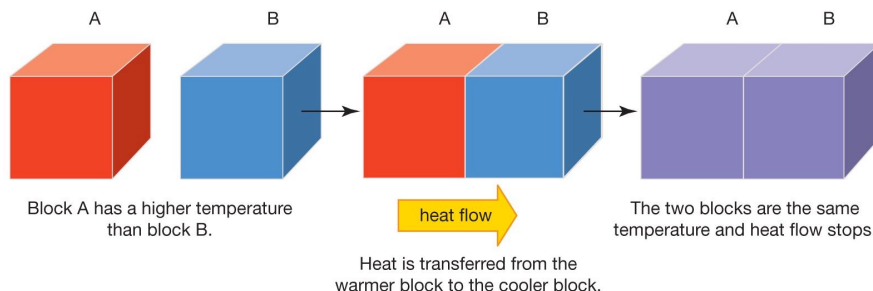


Figure 2: Heat Transfer

This behavior reflects the underlying molecular basis of temperature: **hot** substances possess particles with greater average KE—vibrating and moving more rapidly—whereas **cold** substances possess particles with comparatively lower KE. **Temperature**, therefore, is more precisely defined as a measure of the **average kinetic energy** of the particles within a system.

The quantity of heat transferred within a system is given by:

$$q = m \times C \times \Delta T$$

where q denotes the heat transferred, m the mass of the system, C the **specific heat capacity**, and ΔT the change in temperature. **Specific heat capacity** is defined as the quantity of energy required to raise the temperature of 1 g of a substance by 1 K. For water, this value is $4.184 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$, meaning 4.184 joules or energy are required to raise the temperature of 1 g of water by 1 K.

The experimental discipline concerned with measuring the heat exchanged during chemical reactions, physical changes, or thermal interactions between objects is known as **calorimetry**, and constitutes a practical application of the **First Law of Thermodynamics**. Consider the following worked examples.

- (a) **Determine the heat required to raise the temperature of 43g of water by 45K.**

$$q = (43 \text{ g})(4.184 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1})(45 \text{ K}) = 8096.04 \text{ J}$$

While the joule is the standard unit of energy in chemistry, the **calorie** is another commonly encountered unit, defined as 4.184 J. Notably, this equivalence renders the specific heat capacity of water exactly $1 \text{ cal g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$. It should be noted that the dietary Calorie (Cal), as reported on nutritional labels, corresponds to 1 kilocalorie (kcal), or 1000 calories.

- (b) **A 560 g sample of Au at 100°C is placed into 560 mL of water at 20°C. Determine the final equilibrium temperature of the system. Given: $C_{\text{H}_2\text{O}} = 4.184 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$, $C_{\text{Au}} = 0.13 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$.**

By the conservation of energy, the total heat change within a closed system must equal zero:

$$q_{\text{lost}} + q_{\text{gained}} = 0 \implies q_{\text{gained}} = -q_{\text{lost}}$$

Since heat flows from the Au to the water, the Au loses energy while the water gains energy, and both reach a common final temperature T_{final} . Substituting into the calorimetry equation:

$$(560 \text{ g})(4.184 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1})(T_{\text{final}} - 20) = -(560 \text{ g})(0.13 \text{ J g}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1})(T_{\text{final}} - 100)$$

Solving for T_{final} :

$$T_{\text{final}} = 22.41^\circ \text{C}$$

Core Concept 1.7: Phase Transitions

Phase transitions refer to the physical transformation of a substance from one state of matter to another, driven by changes in thermal energy. The heat required to transition water from a solid to a liquid state is termed the **heat of fusion**, while that required to transition water from a liquid to a gaseous state is termed the **heat of vaporization**.

The sign of each quantity is determined by the direction of the transition: positive for melting and vaporization (endothermic), and negative for freezing and condensation (exothermic).

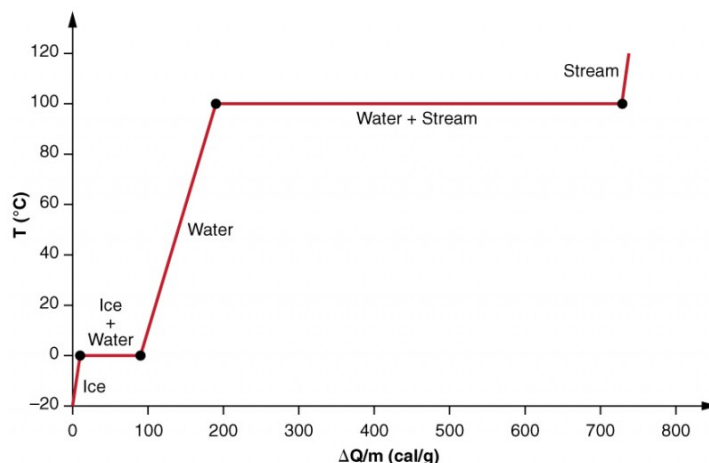


Figure 3: Heating Curve of Water

As illustrated in Figure 3, temperature remains constant during phase transitions. During vaporization, for instance, the energy supplied does not increase the average KE of the molecules (*which temperature measures*), but is instead directed toward increasing the **PE of the IMFs**. At 100°C, water molecules in the liquid phase possess the same average KE as those in the gas phase; however, they remain confined to the liquid state by the deep PE wells created by hydrogen bonding interactions. The heat of vaporization, therefore, represents **the energy required to overcome these IMFs entirely**, liberating the molecules from their neighbors and enabling the transition to the gas phase. *The same reasoning applies analogously to the heat of fusion.*

It is also notable that the heat of vaporization is substantially greater in magnitude than the heat of fusion. This disparity arises because **fusion** requires only sufficient energy to **disrupt the rigid, ordered crystal lattice** of ice—partially weakening intermolecular interactions without eliminating them—whereas **vaporization** necessitates the **complete dissociation** of all intermolecular interactions between water molecules. The energetic difference between these two processes is therefore considerable.

1.3 Enthalpy

Core Concept 1.8: Enthalpy

Enthalpy (H) is a thermodynamic property that represents the total heat content of a system. It accounts for both the internal energy of the system and the energy required to "make room" for it by pushing back the surrounding atmosphere.

While you cannot measure the absolute enthalpy of a system, you can measure the **change in enthalpy (ΔH)** during a process, which is why this term is so central to chemistry.

Let us revisit the bond energy graph from Core Concept 1.3.

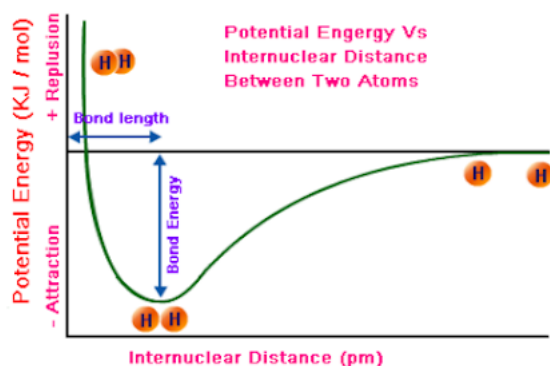
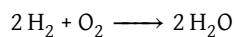


Figure 4: Potential Energy Diagram

The formation of bonds releases energy and the breakdown of bonds requires energy. All chemical reactions are the breakdown of the initial bonds of reactants and the formation of new bonds of products. ΔH is used to denote whether a reaction results in the net input of heat (**endothermic**) or the net release of heat (**exothermic**)

Core Concept 1.9: Enthalpy Example (*Combustion of Hydrogen*)

Take the combustion of hydrogen to produce water for example.



Here is a graph of the enthalpy change during the reaction.

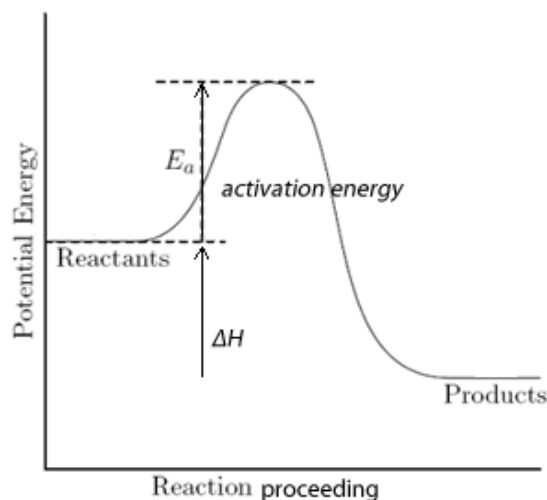


Figure 5: Enthalpy of Combustion

Let's first start off by imagining the reaction occurring in front of you. When you light a balloon of H_2 , you'd see it light up and explode. The fact that heat was released as a result of the reaction should tell you that the reaction was exothermic.

What we saw was that the original reactants (the H_2 within the balloon and the O_2 in the air) were transformed into the products (H_2O) as a result of an initial input of energy (the lighter). We call this initial input of energy as the **activation energy**, the jumpstart in energy the reaction needs to carry out the breakdown of reactant bonds before reforming product bonds.

The fundamental driving force of chemistry is **the pursuit of the lowest PE state**. Thus the bonds of the free atoms (H, H, H, H, O, O) would interact to form 2 H_2O . And since the enthalpies of the bonds exist at a lower PE than the original bonds, the net release of heat equal to the net difference in enthalpy occurs (the explosion).

It may be worth noting that a small spark is not enough to fulfill the activation energy of all H_2 and O_2 molecules at once. Instead, the energy release from one spark is sufficient to form one H_2O molecule. The release of energy from the formation this H_2O is then used as the E_a of neighboring H_2 and O_2 molecules. This domino effect occurs at a rapid rate to carry out the reaction for the entire balloon.

We can represent the enthalpy change quantitatively as well. These are the average bond enthalpy values for several commonly occurring bonds.

Bond	H-H	O-O	H-O	C-C	C=C	$\text{C}\equiv\text{C}$	C-O	O=O
H_{average} (kJ/mol)	436	146	463	348	612	838	360	498

We can calculate the enthalpy change for the breakdown and formation of each bond as follows:

Break 2 moles of H-H $\rightarrow (2)(+436 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

Break 1 moles of O=O $\rightarrow (1)(+498 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

Make 4 moles of O-H $\rightarrow (4)(-463 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

Thus $\Delta H = -482 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ for the reaction.

It is also important to remember that E_a is rarely the energy required to break ALL the reactant bonds. E_a is **only the energy needed to break key reactant bonds just enough for the reaction to occur**. For instance the E_a of water formation is only 200 kJ mol^{-1} , not the entire 1370 kJ mol^{-1} required to break all reactant bonds.

Core Concept 1.10: Enthalpy Example (Autoionization of Water)

Let's take a look at another example: the autoionization of water.

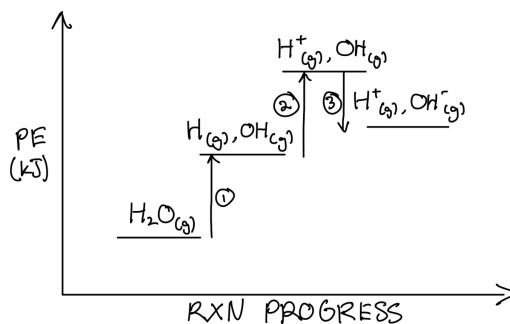


Figure 6: Autoionization of Water Enthalpy

Here, we see a net rise in PE, making the overall reaction endothermic ($\Delta H > 0$). The reaction is separated into three distinct steps

(1) Break 1 mole of O-H $\rightarrow (1)(+467 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

(2) Pull e^- from 1 mole of H ("ionization energy") $\rightarrow (1)(+1312 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

(3) Add e^- to 1 mole of O ("electron affinity") $\rightarrow (1)(-180 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})$

Thus $\Delta H = +1599 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ for the reaction.

Core Concept 1.11: Hess's Law

If two or more chemical equations are added to give another chemical equation, the corresponding enthalpies of each reaction can be added to obtain the enthalpy of the combined reaction. This is called **Hess's Law**. Enthalpies are **state functions**, meaning it does not matter what path you take, the altitude difference is the same.

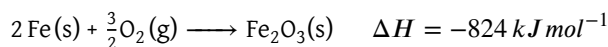
$$\Delta H_{\text{Rxn}} = \sum \Delta H_f(\text{products}) - \sum \Delta H_f(\text{reactants})$$

In other words, this formula is equivalent to **undoing the formation of the reactants** and then **doing the formation of the products**.

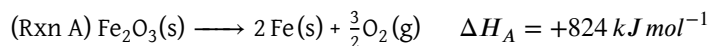
Core Concept 1.12: Enthalpy Example (Iron Smelting)

Lets take a look at the reaction of iron oxide with carbon.

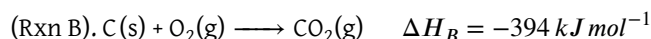
This is the chemical equation of the formation of iron oxide. The reaction is exothermic.



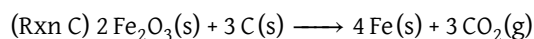
Thus the opposite reaction (*iron oxide decomposition*) is endothermic. We'll call this reaction **Rxn A**.



Let's also take a look at the combustion of carbon. We'll call this reaction **Rxn B**.



When we combine 2 Rxn A with 3 Rxn B, we get the following reaction of iron oxide with carbon. We'll call this reaction **Rxn C**.



Based on Hess's Law, the sum of the enthalpy changes of 2 Rxn A and 3 Rxn B is equal to the enthalpy change of the combined reaction.

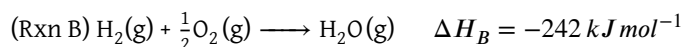
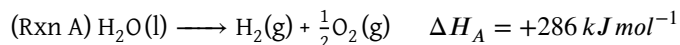
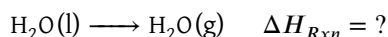
$$\Delta H_C = 2\Delta H_A + 3\Delta H_B = +466 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$$

Thus, it would take $+466 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ to deoxidize 2 moles of iron oxide or $+233 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ to deoxidize 1 mole of iron oxide. Making this process much more favorable compared to the $+824 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$ net enthalpy change in the absence of carbon.

This chemical reaction is process of smelting raw iron ore into pure iron.

Core Concept 1.13: Enthalpy Example (Vaporization of Water)

Let's look at another example of the formation of $\text{H}_2\text{O}(\text{g})$ from $\text{H}_2\text{O}(\text{l})$ at 25°C .



Thus

$$\Delta H_{\text{Rxn}} = \Delta H_{\text{A}} + \Delta H_{\text{B}} = +44 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$$

or

$$\Delta H_{\text{Rxn}} = \sum \Delta H_{\text{f}}(\text{products}) - \sum \Delta H_{\text{f}}(\text{reactants})$$

In other words, this formula is equivalent to **undoing the formation of the reactants** and then **doing the formation of the products**.

2 Entropy

2.1 Defining Entropy

Enthalpy is just one factor in predicting whether a reaction will be favorable or unfavorable. For instance, the dissociation of ammonium chloride into its corresponding ions is endothermic, yet it goes to completion.



What about the tendency for gas to expand into a vacuum? Although this isn't a reaction, it occurs in only one direction and $\Delta H = 0$, thus it cannot be explained by enthalpy alone.

Core Concept 2.1: Entropy & The Second Law of Thermodynamics

There is a natural tendency for energy and matter to disperse. In chemistry terms, this means that systems tend to react towards a state with high **entropy**. This is also known as **the second law of thermodynamics**.

Introductory chemistry textbooks often describe entropy as *disorder*. However, this is a very vague definition. Instead, entropy is more accurately defined as a measure of how many different ways (**microstates**) you can achieve a specific result (**macrostate**).

Core Concept 2.2: Entropy (Dice Analogy)

Take the sum of rolling two dice for example. There are a total of 36 different combinations of rolling 2 dice, but the statistical likelihood of sum outcomes is concentrated around 7. The outcome of the sum being 7 is the macrostate in this case, and the different combinations of possible dice rolls (6-1, 5-2, 4-3, 3-4, 2-5, 1-6) are the microstates. It is much less likely to be at a low entropy macrostate (*like the sum of 2*) than a high entropy macrostate (*like the sum of 7*) because of the number of valid microstates for each macrostate.

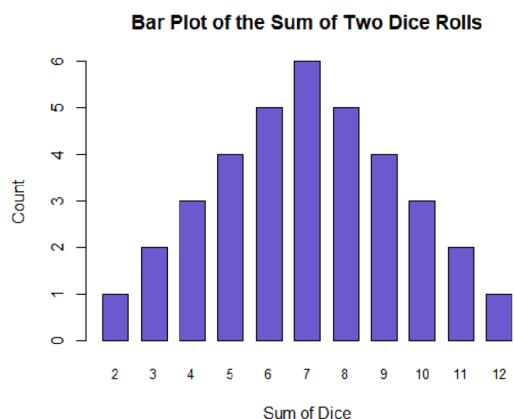


Figure 7: Dice Roll Probability Distribution

Core Concept 2.3: Entropy (Gas Molecule Traits)

Now let's think about this in the context of gas molecules within a closed container at 25°C. Intuitively, we can expect the gas to spontaneously disperse throughout the container volume. Just as rolling a sum of 7 on two dice is the most likely macrostate because of its high number of possible microstates (*number combinations*), the gas utilizing the entire container volume is the most likely macrostate because of its higher number of possible microstates (*positional combinations*). The low entropy macrostate counterpart is if all gas molecules concentrate into one corner of the container. There are much less possible microstates in which the gas molecules can arrange themselves in when restricted to a small corner compared to the entire container.

The following figure shows this concept nicely but at a smaller scale.

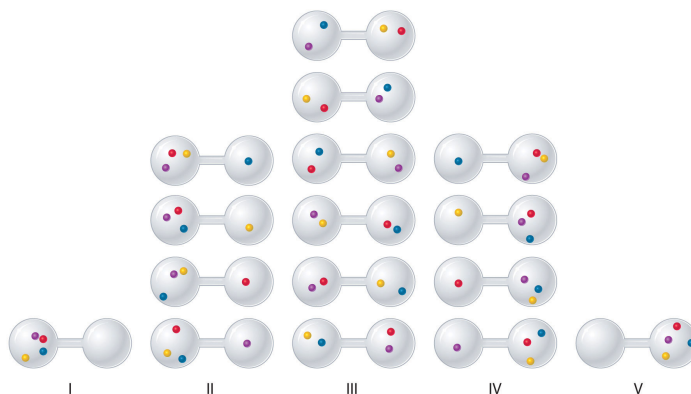


Figure 8: Gas Molecule Position Microstates

So far, we've only talked about the coordinate positions of the gas molecules. In reality, there are also many other characteristics that we can include to expand the number of possible microstates there are for a given macrostate: rotational position, vibrational motion, translational motion, magnitude of KE, etc.

Dimensions tied to KE are consequently tied to temperature.

Like the gas molecule coordinate positions, there are more possible microstates in which the distribution of T in the form of KE is more widely distributed across the entire container volume compared to being concentrated

in one corner, hence the tendency for heat to transfer into cooler surroundings.

When we say that the gas molecules are at 25°C, we're actually referring to the average KE of the gas molecules, NOT all gas molecules being at the KE equivalent of 25°C simultaneously. At a random time instance, one gas molecule could be at the KE equivalent of 24.99°C, and another at 25.01°C. With that being said, there are many more possible microstates in which the KE magnitudes of the gas molecules are within a wider range compared to all being at that of 25°C.

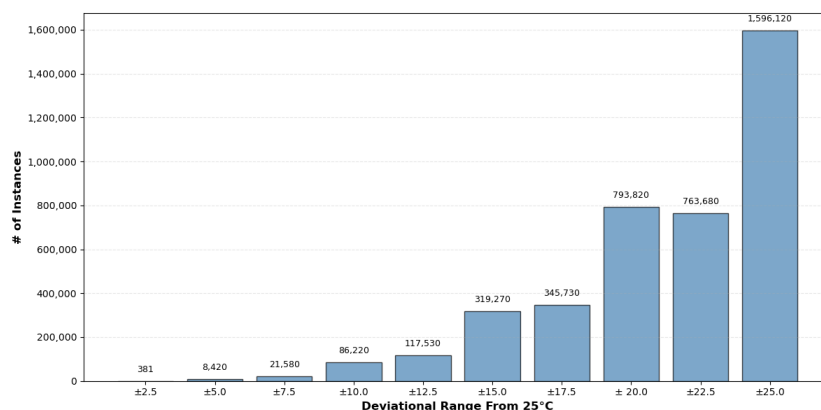


Figure 9: Gas Kinetic Energy Distribution

The graph above represents the counts of possible 5 number permutations that sum to 125 (and thus average out to 25) separated by the maximum deviation from 25 that was allowed. The possible permutation ranges were also constrained to 0-50 inclusive for the sake of simplicity. As you can see, even in an extremely simplified model like this, there is a much larger number of possible microstates where the temperature ranges are more widely distributed than when all gas molecules are at the same KE such as the permutation (25, 25, 25, 25, 25). Thus there is a tendency for heat to be distributed more randomly through out gas molecules although the average KE is still 25°C. This is the **Maxwell-Boltzmann Distribution** that we've visited *1.2.1 Kinetic Molecular Theory and Ideal Gas Laws*.

Core Concept 2.4: Boltzmann Equation

With that being said, entropy (S) can be defined through the **Boltzmann equation**.

$$S = k_B \ln(W)$$

where W represents the number of energetically equivalent microstates of a system and k_B is the Boltzmann's constant represented as

$$k_B = \frac{R}{N_A} = \frac{8.314 \text{ J K}^{-1} \text{ mol}^{-1}}{6.022 \times 10^{23} \text{ units}} = 1.38 \times 10^{-23} \text{ J K}^{-1}$$

where R is the ideal gas constant in $\text{J K}^{-1} \text{ mol}^{-1}$ and N_A is Avogadro's number, which represents the number of units per mole. k_B tell us how much thermal energy is contained in a single particle for every degree of temperature in a system.

And from our discussion of entropy, we can see that the change in number of accessible microstates is exponentially related to the change in the number of particles, thus the proportionality of entropy is to $\ln(W)$ and not simply W . This relationship will be brought back to in *3.2.3 Gibbs Free Energy and Equilibrium Constants*.

In more general terms, entropy increase ($\Delta S > 0$) as (1) temperature increases, (2) a reaction results in a net increase in number of molecules, and (3) a phase change towards more unstable phases occurs. When presented with more nuanced cases, always revert back to whether the change or reaction will increase or decrease the number of possible microstates.

2.2 Changes in Entropy

Core Concept 2.5: The Third Law of Thermodynamics

The **third law of thermodynamics** states that as the T of a system approaches absolute zero (0 Kelvin), its entropy approaches a constant minimum value, which is 0 for a perfect, pure crystal. This is critical because it enables us to quantify the absolute entropy of a system, molecule, mole of a substance, etc. Recall that we could not do the same with enthalpy because we could not quantify the absolute enthalpy of a system due to the absence of an absolute reference point (*we could only calculate its change*).

Core Concept 2.6: Entropy & Temperature

We measure entropy in the units of **Joules per Kelvin (J/K)**. While this unit may be difficult to wrap your head around, it is easier when compared to a similar unit like grams per liter (g/L) or density. Just as how density is a descriptive value of a substance of how much mass it would have at a certain volume, entropy is a descriptive value of how large the range of microstates it has access to (quantified as energy) for a certain temperature.

It's also important to keep in mind that **the entropy of a system (the ratio J/K) increases with temperature**, but at a decreasing rate. Conceptually, we can imagine inputting the same amount of energy into a system of boiling water vs ice. The boiling water is already at a state of high entropy thus a 1 K increase in temperature does a lot less percent change to the system compared to a 1 K increase in temperature for ice, which is at a state of low entropy. We express this mathematically as

$$\frac{dS}{dT} = \frac{C_p}{T}$$

This equation says that the rate at which entropy increases with temperature is proportional to the heat capacity of the system and inversely proportional to the temperature. We explained why entropy is inversely proportional to temperature above. C_p is proportional to the rate of entropy change because a higher C_p indicates a higher input of energy per Kelvin increased in temperature. For instance, you'd need to input a lot more energy to raise water by 1 K compared to Cu. Because you are pumping in so many Joules just to move the needle by 1 K for water, you are creating a massive amount of new molecular "chaos", whereas you aren't putting in as much energy in Cu for a 1 K uptick, thus less new "disorder".

Core Concept 2.7: Thought Experiment (*Increasing the Temperature of Water*)

Let's discuss the case of increasing the temperature of water from 25°C to 50°C in the context of enthalpy and entropy.

Enthalpy is simple calorimetry as we've learned previously. ΔH is simply the products of mol_{H_2O} , C_{H_2O} , and ΔT .

In order to quantify this energy input through entropy gain, we must consider (1) the increasing entropy of water as T increases and (2) the decreasing rate at which entropy increases as T increase. Mathematically, this is summarized as

$$\frac{dS}{dT} > 0, \frac{d^2S}{dT^2} < 0$$

The area under the curve of a line graph presenting S as a function of T , from the initial T to the final T , represents the access to a greater number of microstates and/or a higher entropy. The overall shape of the line would be similar to $f(x) = \ln(x)$.

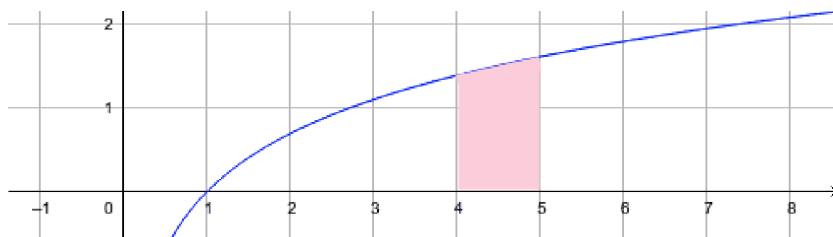


Figure 10: Entropy vs Temperature

When we get really nuanced with the definitions of entropy and enthalpy, we realize that enthalpy is a measure of temperature dependent entropy characteristics in a way. The limitations of enthalpy is that you cannot quantify the change in entropy dependent on positional coordinates, which stretch outside the scope of this course.

3 Gibbs Free Energy

3.1 Gibbs Free Energy

Core Concept 3.1: Deriving the Gibbs Free Energy Equation

Okay, now let's revisit the **second law of thermodynamics** which states that the total entropy of an isolated system always increases over time. Our universe is essentially an isolated system (*albeit a very large one*), thus we can represent this law as the equation

$$\Delta S_{universe} = \Delta S_{system} + \Delta S_{environment} > 0$$

Let's look at a scenario where we melt 10 moles of water. The energy inputted into the system would be the enthalpy of fusion, and since the temperature of the system is static during phase changes, we do not need any integral calculations. Thus the entropy change of the ice cube (the system) would be

$$\Delta S_{system} = \frac{\Delta H_{fusion}}{T_{system}} = \frac{(6.02 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})(10 \text{ mol})}{273 \text{ K}} = +220 \text{ J K}^{-1}$$

As for the surroundings, the temperature does increase (*in theory*), but the shift is negligible due to the surroundings being quite literally the rest of the universe. As a result, we keep $T_{surroundings}$ at 298K. In most chemistry problems, the "surroundings" are modeled as a **thermal reservoir**. By definition, a reservoir is so large that its heat capacity is effectively infinite in comparison to the system.

With this in mind, the corresponding entropy change of the surroundings would be

$$\Delta S_{surroundings} = \frac{-\Delta H_{fusion}}{T_{surroundings}} = \frac{-(6.02 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1})(10 \text{ mol})}{298 \text{ K}} = -202 \text{ J K}^{-1}$$

Consequently, $S_{universe}$ would then be

$$\Delta S_{universe} = \Delta S_{system} + \Delta S_{surroundings} = 220 J K^{-1} + (-202 J K^{-1}) = +18 J K^{-1}$$

Conceptually, this means that (1) the entropy of the system increased due to the input of heat into the system and (2) the entropy of the surroundings decreased due to the transfer of heat from the surroundings to the system (but to a lesser degree because the marginal difference in the context of the greater temperature of the surroundings is smaller as we've explained previously).

Let's algebraically manipulate the equation for $S_{universe}$.

$$\Delta S_{uni} = \Delta S_{surr} + \Delta S_{sys} > 0$$

$$\Delta S_{uni} = \frac{-\Delta H_{sys}}{T_{surr}} + \Delta S_{sys} > 0$$

$$T_{surr} \Delta S_{uni} = -\Delta H_{sys} + T_{surr} \Delta S_{sys} > 0$$

$$-T_{surr} \Delta S_{uni} = \Delta H_{sys} - T_{surr} \Delta S_{sys} < 0$$

We have just defined the **Gibbs free energy** equation where $\Delta G = -T_{surr} \Delta S_{uni}$.

$$\Delta G = \Delta H_{sys} - T_{surr} \Delta S_{sys} < 0$$

Core Concept 3.2: Gibbs Free Energy

Gibbs free energy is another way to conveying whether the total entropy of the universe is increasing or not (a net spontaneity score). It acts as a balancing act between two universal desires: (1) to maximize the entropy of the universe (2) to minimize the enthalpy of the system. If a reaction fulfills both conditions, the reaction is **spontaneous**. If a reaction does not fulfill both conditions, the reaction is **non-spontaneous**. If a reaction fulfills only one, the reaction's spontaneity is determined by which force is greater.

ΔH°	ΔS°	T	ΔG°	Reaction Favorability
–	+	ANY	–	Product favored (→)
–	–	HIGH	+	Reactant favored (←)
–	–	LOW	–	Product favored (→)
+	+	HIGH	–	Product favored (→)
+	+	LOW	+	Reactant favored (←)
+	–	ANY	+	Reactant favored (←)

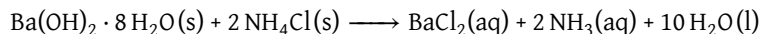
ΔG_{rxn} measures the difference between the free energies of the reactants and products when all components of the reaction are present at standard-state conditions. ΔG_{rxn} can be either calculated from coresponding ΔH_{rxn} and ΔS_{rxn} values or from the the Gibbs free energies of formation (ΔG_f). Like both enthalpy and entropy are state functions, ΔG_{rxn} is also a state function.

$$\Delta G_{rxn} = \Delta G_f(\text{products}) - \Delta G_f(\text{reactants})$$

An easy way to conceptualize the Gibbs free energy equation is to treat ΔS as a scaling factor for the effect of temperature on free energy.

Core Concept 3.3: Gibbs Free Energy Example (*Barium Hydroxide & Ammonium Chloride Reaction*)

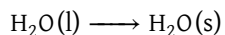
Let's take a look at the reaction between barium hydroxide and ammonium chloride.



This reaction is highly endothermic ($\Delta H = 62 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}$). However, just by first glance at the states of the reactants vs products, we can see that this reaction raises entropy tremendously ($\Delta S = 368 \text{ J mol}^{-1} \text{ K}^{-1}$). Thus the free energy provided by the product entropy is much greater than that of the reactant entropy at the same temperature because the products have an access to a greater number of possible microstates due to several factors (*number of moles of molecules, phases, etc*). The magnitude of this "entropic energy" gain at 298K is greater than the magnitude of the enthalpy increase the reaction provides, thus the reaction is favored.

Core Concept 3.4: Thought Experiment (*Liquid Water at Absolute Zero*)

Let's imagine water states at a theoretical temperature of 0 Kelvin. We already know that liquid water will freeze at absolute zero but why? First, let us take a look at the freezing phase change reaction.



The process is exothermic thus the process is enthalpically favorable. However, the entropy falls as the phase change from liquid to solid occurs. Yet this entropy drop does not matter in the context of absolute zero because the free energy (*or access to microstates*) of liquid water and solid water would be the same. *It is counterintuitive to conceptualize liquid water at absolute zero because water as we know it doesn't exist in the liquid state at absolute zero. But this phenomenon is exactly what we are trying to explain.* At absolute zero, entropic free energy is zero, thus the only factor that matters is enthalpy.

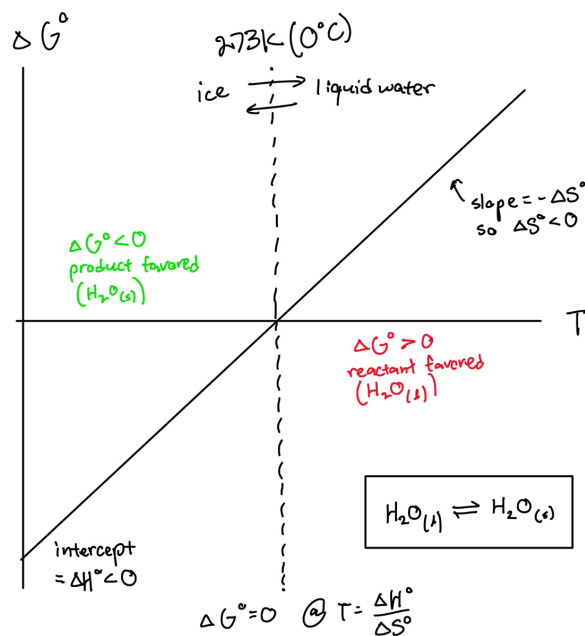


Figure 11: Gibbs Free Energy of Water

At higher temperatures, the free energy bound the entropy of liquid state of water is always greater than that of the solid state. However, until this difference in free energy bound to entropy surpasses the enthalpic change that occurs during freezing (*which approaches as T increases*), the frozen state of water is favored. It is at 273K that we see the phase change from solid to liquid occur. This is where free energy bound to entropy drops too much during a freezing reaction to push Gibbs free energy into the positives, thus the freezing phase change reaction is not favored and the reverse is favored.

The Gibbs free energy equation allows us to gauge the favorability of a reaction by comparing the free energies provided by the enthalpy changes across the reactants and products and the free energies provided by the entropy change across the reactants and products. Entropy changes at a higher surrounding T will magnify the effects of entropy differences on free energy. This is because at higher temperatures, the system has more thermal energy to distribute among its available microstates, making the free energy "reward" for an already greater number of microstates (high entropy) much larger vs a lower number of microstates (low entropy). The universe always wants to minimize free energy or the potential to do spontaneous work.

3.2 Free Energy & Equilibrium

Core Concept 3.5: Gibbs Free Energy & Equilibrium

We have established so far that if a reaction's ΔG is negative, it is favorable, and if it is positive, it is unfavorable. However, from EXTERNAL REFERENCE TO EQUILIBRIUM, we know that just because a reaction is favorable, it does not mean that it goes to completion. Many reactions find an equilibrium point where some reactants or products are still leftover although their presence is not favored in the context of ΔG .

There must thus be a quantitatively defined relationship between ΔG and K . Here, we introduce the **Van't Hoff Isotherm equation**.

$$\Delta G^\circ = -RT \ln K$$

Based on our previous establishment of $S = k_B \ln(W)$, we can see that entropy has a logarithmic relationship with the number of possible microstates (*which shift exponentially to the number molecules in a system*). Since K relates to the concentrations (*or the amounts*) of reactants and products, the accessible number of microstates change exponentially when Q shifts. Thus since ΔG incorporates ΔS into its value, the relationship between K and ΔG is logarithmic. Consequently, a linear change in ΔG leads to an exponential change in K .

Also recognize the relationship between ΔG and T . A change in T will have an effect on the magnitude of ΔG but also shift the value of K based on the ΔH of the reaction. The T at which K is exactly 1 would be when neither side of the reaction is inherently favorable and thus there an equal part reactant and product ratio.

Under non-standard conditions in the context of the current reactant product ratio Q . We would represent the total potential free energy left in the system by

$$\Delta G = \Delta G^\circ + RT \ln Q$$

or equivalently

$$\Delta G = -RT \ln \frac{K}{Q}$$

When $K = Q$, we have achieved equilibrium, thus there is no more potential free energy left to do work. If $K > Q$ or $K < Q$, the reaction still has free energy left to do work. In these cases the sign of ΔG represents the direction of the reaction that can perform work.

4 Examples and Applications

4.1 Work

Core Concept 4.1: Free Energy & Work

The free energy released from a system can be converted to **work** and used to **exert influence on an external body**. While reactions that are endothermic but entropy increasing enough to be favorable will be able to fulfill this purpose, it is more common to see reactions that are exothermic to be the source of work. In many cases, these exothermic reactions tend to decrease entropy along the process, thus the free energy that we can use to drive external processes will be less than the total heat released by the reaction.

This is what Gibbs free energy is used for in a practical sense. Let's take a look at the Gibbs free energy equation again.

$$\Delta G = \Delta H - T \Delta S$$

For $\Delta H < 0$, ΔH can be converted into work after "the entropy cost" is paid for.

For $\Delta S < 0$, ΔS must be compensated for in order to satisfy the second law of thermodynamics ("the entropy cost").

For $\Delta S > 0$, ΔS can also be converted into work.

Core Concept 4.2: Work Example (Rube Goldberg Machine)

Let's go through a collective example of how a system's change in entropy and enthalpy can be used to drive work onto an external system.

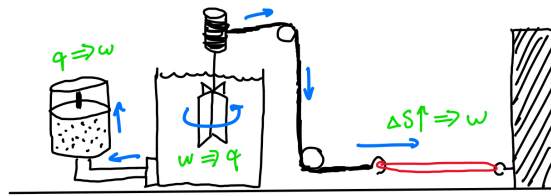


Figure 12: Entropy to Work Conversion

The figure above shows an initial state of a system. In this initial state, the red rubber band is in its stretched, low entropy position because there are fewer microstates in which the chains can be straight compared to its relaxed state where the chains are free to access a larger range of microstates because they aren't confined by the requirement to be straight.

ENTROPY TO WORK: As the rubber band contracts, the free energy provided by this rubber band system's entropy rise is converted into work that pulls the cable it is connected to.

WORK TO HEAT: As the work transferred from the rubber band enters the cable-paddle system (rotating the paddle), it immediately leaves the system as heat is inputted into the water system via friction from the paddle.

HEAT TO ENTROPY TO WORK: This heat energy is transferred onto a gas system within a piston chamber to push the piston up via the gas system's entropy increase due to an increase in volume.

It is important to note that **the process of heat conversion to work is never a perfect conversion**. This is because the quality of energy from work is different from that of heat. Heat is the random vibration of molecules within a system, thus making it inherently high entropy. Work, on the other hand, is the organized motion of molecules within a system, thus making it low entropy. **If heat to work conversion is perfect, the universe will lose entropy in the process** (we know from the second law of thermodynamics that this is impossible), thus a portion of heat is released into the relatively lower temperature surrounding to compensate for the loss of entropy from the heat to work conversion process.

Core Concept 4.3: Internal Energy

Internal energy (E) of a system is the sum of all kinetic and potential energies of all the system's components.

$$\Delta E = q + w$$

Energy gained or lost by the system is equal to the energy lost or gained by the surroundings.

To help us better understand this concept, imagine the transfer of heat energy into two gas systems to T_{final} from $T_{initial}$. We restrain one system to constant volume and the other to constant pressure.

CONSTANT VOLUME: The system is restricted from doing any expansion work to its surroundings, thus 100% of the heat you add goes directly into increasing the E of the system (raising T).

CONSTANT PRESSURE: This system, on the other hand, is free to expand. Thus for the same T increase as the former system, you would need to add extra heat energy (to raise T to T_{final}) equivalent to the energy transferred to the surroundings from the expansion work it will do as volume increases.

It would take more heat energy to raise the temperature of the system with constant pressure than the system with constant volume by the same temperature increase.

4.2 Electrochemical Cells

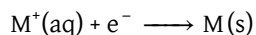
Core Concept 4.4: Electrochemical Cells

An electrochemical cell is a device that bridges the gap between chemical energy and electrical energy, effectively allowing us to use the free energy drop of a spontaneous chemical reaction to generate electrical energy for practical purposes. It works by physically separating a redox (reduction-oxidation; e^- transfer reactions) reaction so that e^- s are forced to travel through an external circuit rather than transferring directly between atoms within a solution.

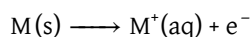
Core Concept 4.5: Electrode Potential

Before introducing electrochemical cells, we first need to understand electrode potentials. **Electrode potential** is a measure of the tendency of a metal to either "shed" its atoms into a solution as ions or "pull" ions from the solution to become part of the metal.

A high electrode potential means the metal is more likely to pull ions from the solution to become part of the metal. This is the reduction of metal ions into neutral metal atoms.



A low electrode potential means the metal is more likely to shed ions into a solution from the metal. This is the oxidation of neutral metal atoms into metal ions.



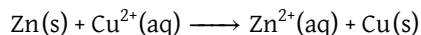
You cannot measure the potential of a single metal electrode in isolation. You always need at least one more metal electrode to compare it to. To solve this, chemists have designated a universal reference point to hydrogen called the **Standard Hydrogen Electrode (SHE)**, which is arbitrarily assigned a value of 0.00 V. Here are the electrode potentials of some common metals:

Potential	Reduction Half-Reaction
-3.05 V	$Li^+(aq) + e^- \longrightarrow Li(s)$
-2.71 V	$Na^+(aq) + e^- \longrightarrow Na(s)$
-2.37 V	$Mg^{2+}(aq) + 2e^- \longrightarrow Mg(s)$
-1.66 V	$Al^{3+}(aq) + 3e^- \longrightarrow Al(s)$
-0.76 V	$Zn^{2+}(aq) + 2e^- \longrightarrow Zn(s)$
-0.28 V	$Ni^{2+}(aq) + 2e^- \longrightarrow Ni(s)$
0.00 V	$2H^+(aq) + 2e^- \longrightarrow H_2(g)$
+0.34 V	$Cu^{2+}(aq) + 2e^- \longrightarrow Cu(s)$
+0.80 V	$Ag^+(aq) + e^- \longrightarrow Ag(s)$
+1.06 V	$Br_2(l) + 2e^- \longrightarrow 2Br^-(aq)$
+1.23 V	$O_2(g) + 4H^+(aq) + 4e^- \longrightarrow 2H_2O(l)$
+1.36 V	$Cl_2(g) + 2e^- \longrightarrow 2Cl^-(aq)$
+2.87 V	$F_2(g) + 2e^- \longrightarrow 2F^-(aq)$

Core Concept 4.6: Galvanic Cell

We assign the units of V or J/C (joules per coulomb or energy per charge) because the potential tells us how much energy each e^- possesses as it spontaneously travels from a low potential electrode to a high potential electrode.

With that being said, if you were to place Zn metal powder into a solution of Cu ions, a spontaneous redox reaction would occur where the solid Zn metal would eventually turn into solid Cu.



Since this redox reaction is spontaneous ($\Delta G < 0$), free energy is released. A **galvanic cell** (a type of *electrochemical cell*) is a set up that allows us to capture this free energy and use it as electricity.

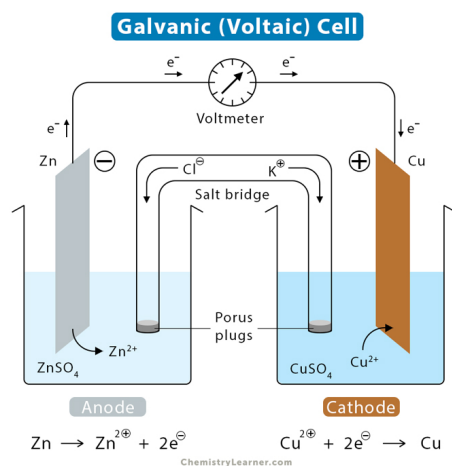


Figure 13: Galvanic Cell Diagram

In a galvanic cell set up, we call the low and high electrode potential metal the anode and cathode, respectively. In the above schematic, the anode is Zn and the cathode is Cu. Since the solutions of the two electrodes are physically separated, the presence of a salt bridge allows each solution to maintain electrical neutrality and keep the redox reaction moving forward rather than slow down and eventually stop due to the eventual build up of one-sided charge (positive ions on the anode from $\text{Zn}^{2+}(\text{aq})$ accumulation and negative ions on the cathode from SO_4^{2-} presence with the decreasing amounts of $\text{Cu}^{2+}(\text{aq})$). The result is a system that captures the potential difference between the two electrodes until the redox reaction is complete, at which point the anode is completely in its aqueous ion form and the cathode is completely in its solid form.

We can express the free energy gained from this system via the following equation:

$$\Delta G^\circ = -nFE^\circ$$

where n is the number of moles of e^- , F is the Faraday constant which measures the amount of charge per mole of e^- (96485 C mol^{-1}), and E° is cell potential or the difference in potential between the anode and the cathode (in the above case it would be $0.34\text{V} - (-0.80\text{V}) = 1.14\text{V}$).

Let's go through a calculation for the galvanic cell above ($\text{Zn(s)} + \text{Cu}^{2+}(\text{aq}) \longrightarrow \text{Zn}^{2+}(\text{aq}) + \text{Cu(s)}$).

$$E_{\text{cell}}^\circ = E_{\text{cathode}}^\circ - E_{\text{anode}}^\circ = 0.34\text{V} - (-0.80\text{V}) = 1.14\text{V}$$

$n = 2\text{mol}$ because two e^- s are being transferred across the cell. Thus

$$\Delta G^\circ = -(2\text{ mol})(96485 \text{ C mol}^{-1})(1.14 \text{ V}) = -219.98 \text{ kJ}$$

It's important to keep in mind that this free energy value is for every mole of the redox reaction that occurs, thus the same galvanic cell with Zn as its limiting reactant would have a free energy value of -219.98 kJ per mole of Zn.

Core Concept 4.7: Concentration Cells

Now we introduce a **concentration cell**, an electrochemical cell that uses the same metal for both the anode and cathode but at different solution concentrations.

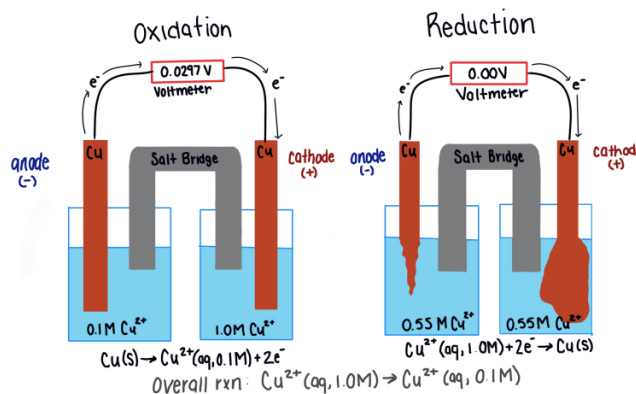
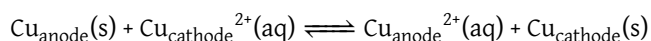


Figure 14: Concentration Cell Diagram

Let's take a look at the chemical equation for the redox reaction in the concentration cell.



The Eq for this reaction is $K = 1$, however

$$Q = \frac{[\text{Cu}_{\text{anode}}^{2+}]}{[\text{Cu}_{\text{cathode}}^{2+}]} < 1$$

Thus, the forward reaction is favored, raising the concentration of the anode solution at the expense of that of the cathode. Via the concentration differences, e^- s flow just like it did in the galvanic cell and we are able to capture the free energy of the redox reaction.

Quantitatively, we can measure the cell potential in volts using the following algebraic manipulations:

$$(\text{STANDARD CONDITIONS}) \quad \Delta G^\circ = -nFE^\circ = -RT \ln(K)$$

$$(\text{NONSTANDARD CONDITIONS}) \quad \Delta G = -nFE$$

$$\Delta G = \Delta G^\circ - (-RT \ln(Q))$$

$$-nFE = -nFE^\circ + RT \ln(Q)$$

$$E = E^\circ - \frac{RT}{nF} \ln(Q)$$

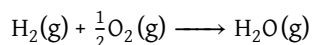
Since E° is always 0 for concentration cells and $\ln(x) = 2.303 \times \log_{10}(x)$, we can simplify the above equation to

$$E = -\frac{0.0592}{n} \log\left(\frac{[M_{\text{anode}}^{n+}]}{[M_{\text{cathode}}^{n+}]}\right)$$

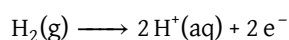
In our example above, $E = 0.0296V$ for $[Cu_{anode}^{2+}] = 0.1M$ and $[Cu_{cathode}^{2+}] = 1.0M$ (or $Q = 0.1$). Because the potential is low compared to that of a galvanic cell, it does not actually provide any practical value in the context of batteries.

Core Concept 4.8: Hydrogen Fuel Cell

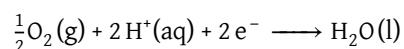
Okay, now we move onto one last type of electrochemical cell called hydrogen fuel cells. **Hydrogen fuel cells** does not use the typical metal elements as the anode and cathode, but rather uses the **hydrogen gas** as the anode and **oxygen gas** as the cathode. It simply utilizes the e^- transfer energy during the process of forming water from these gases.



When we break this chemical reaction down into components we get the anode reaction (oxidation)



and the cathode reaction (reduction)



Here is a schematic of a hydrogen fuel cell.

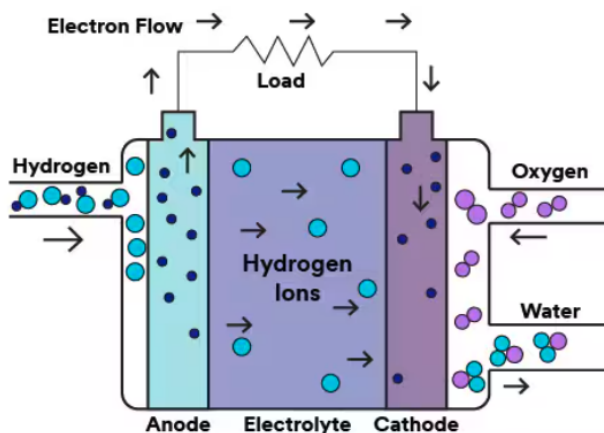


Figure 15: Hydrogen Fuel Cell Diagram

We can quantitatively express the free energy of the hydrogen fuel cell using the same method as we did for the galvanic cell.

$$E_{cell}^{\circ} = E_{oxygen}^{\circ} - E_{hydrogen}^{\circ} = 1.23V - (-0.00V) = 1.23V$$

$$\Delta G^{\circ} = -(2 \text{ mol})(96485 \text{ C mol}^{-1})(1.23 \text{ J J}^{-1}) = -237.35 \text{ kJ}$$

Thus the free energy of a hydrogen fuel cell per mole of H_2 is -237.35 kJ .